10th Class English • Unit 9 • Punjab Board (New Syllabus 2026)

The Road Not Taken — Robert Frost

Fully solved exercises: comprehension, MCQs, reference to the context, summary, inference, integrating sources, sentence structures, pair interview, book review and precis

A. The Poem at a Glance

Poet: Robert Frost (1874–1963), an American poet famous for simple language and deep meaning. **Written:** 1915, published in the collection Mountain Interval (1916). **Form:** four stanzas of five lines each; rhyme scheme **abaab**; the rhythm suggests a man walking and thinking.

Central idea: life is full of choices, and we cannot take every road. A choice may look small at the moment, but it decides the whole direction of a life — "I took the one less traveled by, / And that has made all the difference." The two roads are a **symbol** of the choices of life.

Stanza	What it says (easy meaning)
1	The speaker finds himself where two roads divide in a yellow wood. He is sorry that he, one traveller, cannot walk on both. He stands a long time looking down the first road as far as it bends into the bushes.
2	He takes the other road, because it looks grassy and wanted wear — though the people who had passed there had worn both roads about the same. Both that morning lay covered with fresh leaves that no step had blackened.
3	He decides to keep the first road for another day, knowing that "way leads on to way", and he doubts if he will ever come back. His words show that he knows the choice is final.
4	He says that ages and ages later he will tell this story with a sigh: two roads divided in a wood, and he took the one less travelled by, and that has made all the difference.

Read the poem aloud and notice the words that show hesitation: "And sorry…", "long I stood", "Oh, I kept the first for another day!", "I doubted…", "with a sigh".

B. Glossary — Words and Meanings

Word	Meaning
doubted	felt uncertain about
perhaps	maybe; uncertainty
trodden	walked on
sigh	a deep breath expressing emotion
undergrowth	thick growth of bushes and small trees under larger trees
worn	used or damaged from being used

Word	Meaning
diverged	went in different directions (from the opening line)
hence	from this time; later (as in “ages and ages hence”)

c. Reading and critical thinking — Answer the following questions

1. Where does the speaker find himself at the beginning of the poem?

He finds himself in a **yellow wood**, at a place where a road “diverged” — that is, where one road splits into two. It is autumn, because the leaves are yellow and have fallen, and he is alone as “one traveler”. So he stands at a crossroad in a forest, exactly the position of a man who must choose between two ways of life.

2. Why does the speaker feel sorry that he cannot travel both roads?

He feels sorry because both roads look attractive and he is only one traveller. A human being wants to know everything and to try every possibility, but “being one traveler” he can walk on only one path at a time. The sorrow is not for anything he has lost but for everything he must leave unknown — the other road will remain a mystery forever. This is the central pain of the poem: every choice is also a loss.

3. How does the speaker describe the two roads?

The first road is described as bending “in the undergrowth”, so he could see only a little of it. The second is described as “grassy and wanted wear” — it looked less used and more inviting. But he immediately corrects himself: “though as for that the passing there / Had worn them really about the same”, and again, “both that morning equally lay / In leaves no step had trodden black”. So the two roads were really equal, and the difference existed more in his mind than on the ground.

4. What does the speaker mean when he says he “doubted if he should ever come back”?

He means that once he walks down one road, he knows he will almost certainly never return to this fork to try the other. The reason is given in the previous line: “way leads on to way” — one path leads to another path, one decision leads to another decision, and life carries a man forward until the first fork is far behind him. The line therefore expresses the finality of choice: the roads of life cannot be re-travelled, and time does not allow experiments.

5. Why do you think the speaker saves the first road for another day?

He saves it partly out of hope and partly out of self-deception. He says “Oh, I kept the first for another day!” with an exclamation mark, as if the promise were a comfort; but the very next line admits that he knows it will never happen. So the words are a way of softening the pain of renunciation — human beings often tell themselves “later” when they mean “never”. This is Frost's gentle irony at our own expense.

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6. What emotions does the speaker express when he imagines telling this story “ages and ages hence”?

He imagines telling the story “with a sigh”, and a sigh can carry more than one feeling at the same time. There is **pride**, because he took the harder, less-travelled road; there is **nostalgia**, because he remembers the morning of the choice; there is **wonder** at how one small decision changed everything; and beneath all of it there is a faint **regret**, the eternal question of “what if”. He also exaggerates his own courage a little — it was later generations of readers who noticed that the roads were really the same — and that gentle self-deception is itself a very human emotion.

D. Choose the Correct Option (MCQs) — solved with key

1. Where does the road diverge?

forest mountain
desert river

Answer: forest — The speaker is in a “yellow wood”, that is, a forest in autumn.

2. What colour is the wood described in the poem?

green red
yellow brown

Answer: yellow — The opening line is “Two roads diverged in a yellow wood”.

3. What emotion does the speaker feel about not travelling both roads?

joy anger
sorry fear

Answer: sorry — The second line is “And sorry I could not travel both”.

4. Which road did the speaker eventually take?

busier less-traveled
clearer longer

Answer: less-traveled — “I took the one less traveled by”, though the poem also says both were worn about the same.

5. What covers the roads in the morning?

mud snow
leaves water

Answer: leaves — “In leaves no step had trodden black.”

6. What does the speaker doubt he will do?

return dream
travel rest

Answer: return — “I doubted if I should ever come back.”

7. What type of journey does the road represent?

physical virtual

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emotional (the journey of life) imaginary

Answer: emotional (the journey of life) — The roads are a symbol of life's choices, not of a real walk.

8. What is the speaker doing when he chooses the road?

rushing running
deciding meditation

Answer: deciding — “And sorry I could not travel both… long I stood” — he is weighing his decision.

9. What does the speaker predict he will do in the future?

laugh shout
sigh forget

Answer: sigh — “I shall be telling this with a sigh.”

10. The two roads symbolize choices in _____.

nature life
stories history

Answer: life — The poem is about the choices of life, not about trees and paths.

E. Explain with Reference to the Context

Stanza:

“And both that morning equally lay / In leaves no step had trodden black. / Oh, I kept the first for another day! / Yet knowing how way leads on to way, / I doubted if I should ever come back.”

Part of the answer	What to write
Reference	These lines have been taken from the poem “The Road Not Taken” by the American poet Robert Frost.
Context	The speaker stands in a yellow wood where two roads divide. He has just chosen the second road because it looked grassy and less used, and he is now thinking about the road he did not take.
Explanation	On that morning both roads were covered with fresh fallen leaves that no foot had blackened, so neither road was really more used than the other. The speaker playfully promises to keep the first road for another day, but in the same breath he admits the truth: because one way leads on to another way, he knows he will never come back to this fork.
Critical comment	The lines show the irony of all human choices. The promise “another day” is a comfortable lie, and the word “doubted” admits that a decision once made is almost never undone. This is why the poem ends with a “sigh” rather than with a celebration.

F. Summarising in Your Own Words

1. What choice does the speaker make in the poem? Explain in your own words.

The speaker must choose between two roads in an autumn forest. He looks down the first as far as he can, then takes the second because it seems greener and less used, although both were in fact about the same. He promises himself that he will return for the first road one day, but he knows that he never will, and he later tells the story of this choice with a sigh, saying that it made all the difference in his life.

2. Why is it important to use your own words instead of copying the original text when summarising?

Using your own words proves that you have understood the text and not just copied it, and it forces you to find the main idea instead of repeating every word. A summary that copies the original keeps its length, its figurative language and its ornament, so it is not a summary at all. Your own words also make the meaning clear to a reader who may not have read the original, and they prevent the mistake of plagiarism.

3. Which punctuation marks help make a summary clearer and more organised?

Full stops separate the ideas and keep the sentences short; **commas** separate listed ideas and show pauses; **semicolons** join two closely connected ideas; **colons** introduce a list or an explanation; **quotation marks** are used when you must quote a few key words of the original; and **dashes or brackets** add a short explanation without breaking the sentence. Correct punctuation, together with the connectors “however”, “therefore” and “in addition”, is what makes a summary read smoothly.

4. Summarise the speaker's emotions in two or three sentences, using appropriate connectors.

The speaker begins with **regret**, because he cannot travel both roads; **however**, he soon feels **curiosity and quiet satisfaction** in the road he chooses. **Later**, he feels **uncertainty**, because he knows that one choice leads to another and he will never return. **Finally**, he looks back on the moment with **nostalgia and a sigh**, and with a quiet **pride** that his decision “has made all the difference”.

G. Making Inferences — Reading Between the Lines

1. What can you infer about the speaker's feelings toward his choice at the end of the poem?

We can infer that his feelings are mixed. On the surface he is satisfied, because he says the choice “has made all the difference”; underneath, the word “sigh” hints at doubt and a little regret. He is also aware that he has invented a flattering version of the story — the roads were “really about the same”, yet in the future he will say that he took the less-travelled one. So his feeling at the end is nostalgia coloured by self-justification rather than pure happiness.

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2. What does the “sigh” imply about the speaker's emotions?

A sigh is a breath released when a feeling is too heavy for words. It can mean relief, tiredness, longing or regret, and Frost leaves it open on purpose. In this poem it most likely implies a mixture of longing for the road not taken and acceptance of the road taken — the feeling of an old man who knows that his life was decided on one ordinary morning. The sigh is the poem's honest note: choices are not only made, they are lived with.

3. Based on the description of the two roads, what does the poet suggest about life choices?

Both roads lay “equally” in leaves and were “really about the same”, so the poet suggests that most of life's choices are not obviously good or bad — they look alike at the moment of choosing. What matters is that we must choose, and that after choosing we give the choice a meaning. He also suggests that the difference between two choices is often seen only in hindsight, and that we tend to justify our decisions afterwards by calling our road the less-travelled one.

4. How does the writer's tone (serious, thoughtful) help you understand his point of view?

The tone is calm, reflective and slightly humorous, as if an older person were remembering one morning of his youth. The slow opening (“long I stood”), the quiet exclamations (“Oh, I kept the first for another day!”) and the soft ending (“with a sigh”) make the reader think rather than feel excited. Because the tone never preaches, we accept the poem's point of view — that choices shape a life — as a personal confession rather than a lecture.

5. What conclusion can you draw about the role of decisions in shaping a person's future, according to the poem?

The conclusion is that decisions are the real authors of a life. One apparently small choice, made in a single morning while the leaves were still unbroken, becomes the turning point of a whole biography — “that has made all the difference”. The poem also teaches that the power of a decision lies more in its **finality** than in its loudness: we cannot take both roads, and it is the closed door that gives shape to the life behind it.

H. Interpreting and Integrating Information from Sources

1. If you saw a map with two paths, one busy and one quiet, which path would match the road the speaker chose? Why?

The **quiet path** would match, because the speaker says he took the one “less traveled by” — the road that was “grassy and wanted wear”, that is, less walked on. A busy path would be worn bare of grass, with many footprints and no fresh leaves, so it would belong to the other road, the one he did not take.

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2. How could a flowchart help you understand the speaker's decision-making process?

A flowchart turns the poem into a series of visible steps: **arrive at the fork → look down road one → compare road two → notice both are equal → choose the less-travelled road → promise to return later → admit he never will → tell the story with a sigh**. Seeing the steps in boxes shows the reader that the poem's real subject is not scenery but a **process of decision**, and that the last two boxes are the consequence of the first six.

3. What symbols or images would you include in a diagram about the poem's theme of choice?

I would include: **two roads forking** in a yellow wood (the choice itself); **fallen leaves with no footprints** (both choices equal and new); **grass growing on one road** (the less-travelled way); a **signpost with only one arrow** (we must choose one); a **clock or an hourglass** (time does not allow a second attempt); a **closed door** (the finality of the decision); and a **figure of an old man telling a story** (memory and the meaning we give to our choices).

4. If a graph showed “number of travelers” on each road, what would it reveal about the speaker's choice?

The graph would show a tall bar for the first road and a much shorter bar for the second. It would reveal three things: that the speaker chose the road of the minority, that his choice was unusual rather than popular, and that most people preferred the easier, busier way. Read beside the poem, the graph also gives a gentle warning — the difference between the bars may be very small, since Frost says the two roads were “really about the same”.

5. Why is it helpful to use both the poem and a visual (like a map or chart) to understand the meaning more deeply?

The poem gives **feeling** and the visual gives **structure**. The words “sorry”, “sigh” and “doubted” tell us how the choice felt, while a map or flowchart shows us what actually happened and in what order. Together, the two sources test each other: the chart keeps us from inventing a meaning the poem does not have, and the poem keeps us from reading the chart coldly. This combining of information from different formats is exactly what “integrating sources” means, and it produces a deeper understanding than either source alone.

I. Vocabulary and Grammar — Sentence Patterns and Structures

Type of sentence	Structure	Example from the poem
Simple	One independent clause	The speaker stood at the fork in the road.
Compound	Two independent clauses joined by and, but, or, so	The speaker wanted to take both roads, but he could only choose one.

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Type of sentence	Structure	Example from the poem
Complex	One main clause plus one or more subordinate clauses	Because the two roads looked equally worn, the speaker found it hard to decide.

A. Questions on sentence patterns (model answers)

1. Write a simple sentence describing where the speaker is in the poem.

The speaker stands at a fork in a yellow wood.

2. Create a compound sentence about the speaker's feelings when choosing the road.

He was sorry that he could not travel both roads, so he stood for a long time looking down the first one.

3. Write a complex sentence using “because” to explain why the speaker chose the road he did.

Because the second road was grassy and “wanted wear”, the speaker chose it, even though both roads had been worn about the same.

4. Join two ideas from the poem using “but” or “although”.

He promised that he would keep the first road for another day, **but** he knew that way leads on to way. / **Although** both roads lay equally in leaves that morning, he decided that he had taken the less-travelled one.

5. Why is it important to use different types of sentences when writing about a poem or story?

Different sentences do different work: a **simple** sentence gives a fact clearly and makes a strong point; a **compound** sentence balances two equal ideas such as choice and regret; a **complex** sentence shows cause, condition or time, which is exactly what analysis needs. Writing only one kind of sentence makes a paragraph flat and childish, while a mix of long and short sentences creates rhythm and keeps the reader awake.

B. Complex sentences and paragraphs (model answers)

1. What is the difference between a main clause and a subordinate clause?

A **main clause** has a subject and a verb and can stand alone as a complete sentence: “the speaker chose the second road”. A **subordinate clause** also has a subject and a verb, but it cannot stand alone, because it begins with a connector such as because, although, when or if: “because the grass was greener”. The subordinate clause depends on the main clause for its full meaning.

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2. Write a complex sentence about the speaker's decision, using “because” as a connector.

Because the first road disappeared into the undergrowth, the speaker chose the second one, although he knew that both were equally covered with leaves.

3. Which transitional device could you use to show a contrast between the two roads?

However — “One road bent into the undergrowth; however, the other was grassy and seemed less used.” Other devices of contrast are “on the other hand”, “in contrast”, “whereas” and “yet”.

4. Create a complex sentence that explains why the speaker sighed in the future.

He will tell the story with a sigh, because although his choice gave his life its direction, he still wonders what the other road would have made of him.

5. Why is it important to use different clauses and transitional words when writing a paragraph?

Clauses and transitions are the joints of a paragraph. Without them the writer can only put short statements side by side (“The road was yellow. He stood. He chose.”), and the reader must guess the connection. With them, the relation between ideas becomes visible: “**Although** the wood was yellow and beautiful, he chose quickly, **because** the light was failing; **therefore** he never returned.” The paragraph then reads as one argument instead of a list.

J. Oral Communication Skills — “The Roads We Choose”

How to conduct the pair interview: ask one question at a time, listen without interrupting, ask a follow-up question beginning with “why” or “how”, and give your own example too. Then report your partner's answers to the class in the third person, using the words “he said” and “she explained”.

Model interview (questions and answers)

Q: Have you ever faced two choices where you could only pick one? How did you decide which “road” to take?

A: Yes, at the end of class nine. I could either take science or commerce. I chose science because I had always been curious about how things work, and my uncle, who is an engineer, let me spend a week in his workshop. That week decided it.

Q: Did you ever wonder what would have happened if you had chosen differently?

A: Sometimes, especially in the months when the physics papers were hard. But I have noticed that this wondering comes mostly on bad days; on good days I never think about the other road at all.

Q: Do you usually choose the easy way or the more challenging path?

A: Honestly, I choose the easy way first and then feel guilty. But the difficult choices I have made — like joining the school debating team with a stammer — have taught me the most.

Q: What is one decision that made a big difference in your life?

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A: Deciding to help my younger sister with her mathematics every evening. I became a teacher at home, and my own marks improved because I had to understand everything twice.

Model report to the class: My partner Ali told me that he chose science over commerce after spending a week in his uncle's workshop, and that he sometimes wonders about the other road, but mostly on difficult days. He admitted that he usually prefers the easy way, and yet his biggest change came from a hard choice — joining the debating team with a stammer. He also said that teaching his sister mathematics every evening improved his own studies. In the language of Frost's poem, Ali's “less travelled” road was the tougher road of speaking and teaching.

K. Writing Skills — Book Review, Precis, Paraphrase, Summary

A **book review** has five parts: **introduction** (title, author, genre, theme), **summary** (plot, characters, setting — without spoilers), **analysis** (style, themes, character development, pacing, emotional impact), **opinion** (what you liked or disliked and why) and **conclusion** (overall judgement and a recommendation).

1. What are the key components of a well-written book review?

They are the five parts named above: an introduction that places the book, a short summary that does not spoil the reader's pleasure, an analysis of how the book is written, an honest personal opinion supported by reasons from the text, and a conclusion with a clear recommendation of the kind of reader who would enjoy it.

2. How does the analysis section of a book review differ from the summary?

The **summary** tells what happens — it describes the story, the characters and the setting. The **analysis** tells how and why it works — it judges the writer's style, imagery, structure, pacing, character development and emotional effect, and it supports every judgement with evidence. A summary can be written by someone who has not thought about the book; an analysis cannot.

3. What makes a good personal opinion in a book review?

A good opinion is **specific** (“the ending felt rushed”, not “it was bad”), **supported by evidence from the text**, and **honest about its own bias** (“I like happy endings, so I may be unfair here”). It also separates the book from the reader: disliking a character is not the same as the book being weak.

4. What are some ways you can evaluate a book's writing style or theme?

For **style**, look at the sentence length and rhythm, the choice of words (simple or ornate), the use of imagery and figures of speech, the tone and the point of view. For **theme**, ask what the book keeps returning to, what its central conflict is, what the ending teaches and whether the message is shown by events or only stated by characters. Compare it with other books of the same kind to judge whether it is original.

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5. Why is it important to avoid spoilers in the summary of a book review?

Because a review is written for a reader who has not yet read the book. If the reviewer reveals the ending or the main twist, the reader loses the surprise, the suspense and the reason to read it — the review then replaces the book instead of recommending it. A good summary stops at the moment of tension and says only enough to make the reader curious.

6. In your own words, how would you write a conclusion for a book review?

I would begin with one sentence that sums up the book's overall worth, then name its strongest quality and its one weakness, and finish with a clear recommendation in one sentence: “This book is worth reading for its …; readers who enjoy … will find it excellent, though those who prefer … may find it slow.” The conclusion should not introduce a new point; it should close the door gently.

7. Choose a book you have read recently and write a short review.

Introduction: The Old Man and the Sea by Ernest Hemingway is a short novel about an old Cuban fisherman, Santiago, who has gone eighty-four days without a fish. It is a story of courage, patience and dignity.

Summary: Santiago sails far out alone and hooks a giant marlin. For two days and two nights he holds the line, bleeding and cramped, and at last he kills the fish — only to lose its flesh to sharks on the way home, so that he returns with nothing but the skeleton.

Analysis: Hemingway's style is famously plain: short sentences, few adjectives and a great deal of silence. This simplicity suits the subject, because the old man's life is simple too. The sea, the fish and the sharks work as symbols of nature, of human effort and of the losses that come after every struggle. The pacing is slow on purpose; the reader feels the length of the fight as Santiago feels it.

Opinion: I found the book both moving and hard. I liked the old man's refusal to complain and the line “A man can be destroyed but not defeated”, which stayed in my mind for days. What I did not like was the slowness of the middle section, though I now understand that the slowness is the point.

Conclusion: Overall, it is a small book with a large heart, and I recommend it to readers who like simple language carrying deep meaning. Anyone who has ever worked hard and lost something will recognise Santiago.

Precis writing

A **precis** is a short, clear restatement of the main idea of a passage in your own words: it keeps the essential meaning, drops the examples and the figurative language, keeps the tone, and is usually no more than one-third of the original.

1. What is the main purpose of a precis?

Its purpose is to give the reader the complete sense of a passage in the shortest possible space, without adding any opinion of your own and without losing anything important. It is a test of understanding: if the precis is accurate, the reader of the precis needs nothing more.

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2. What are the key characteristics of a good precis?

It is **brief** (usually one-third of the original), **clear** (simple sentences and logical order), **faithful** (no change of meaning and no added opinion), **in your own words**, **well connected** (transitions such as however and therefore) and **written in the third person and the same tense** as the original.

3. Why is it important to avoid including unnecessary details when writing a precis?

Because details are the leaves and the main idea is the tree. If you keep the examples, the repetition and the imagery, you have written a copy and not a precis, and the reader loses the main point in the middle of trimmings. A precis saves the reader's time only if every sentence in it carries a necessary idea.

4. Rewrite a different passage from “The Road Not Taken” as a precis.

Passage: “I shall be telling this with a sigh / Somewhere ages and ages hence: / Two roads diverged in a wood, and I— / I took the one less traveled by, / And that has made all the difference.”

Precis: Years later, the speaker will remember with a sigh that once two roads divided in a wood, that he chose the less-travelled one, and that this single choice changed the whole course of his life.

Paraphrasing and objective summary

1. Paraphrase the line: “I took the one less traveled by, / And that has made all the difference.”

Paraphrase: I chose the road that fewer people had walked on, and that decision changed everything in my life.

What is kept: the meaning (a less popular choice changed his life) and the tone of quiet reflection. **What is changed:** the poetic word order and “by” are simplified, and “all the difference” becomes “changed everything in my life”.

2. What are the key elements you should include when writing an objective summary of a poem?

Include the **main idea or message**, the **situation** (who speaks, where, and about what), the **key images or symbols** that carry the meaning, and the **tone** — all in your own words. Leave out personal opinion, unnecessary examples, and the ornamental language of the poem itself.

3. Summarise the message of “The Road Not Taken” in one or two sentences.

Standing at a fork in a wood, a traveller must choose one of two roads that look almost the same, and he knows he will never return to try the other. Years later he tells the story with a sigh, saying that his choice made all the difference — so the poem is about the finality and the power of life's decisions.

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L. Summary of the Poem

“The Road Not Taken” by Robert Frost is a four-stanza poem about the choices of life. The speaker stands in a yellow wood where two roads divide, and he is sorry that he, being one traveller, cannot walk on both. He looks down one road as far as it bends into the undergrowth, and then takes the other, which looks grassy and less used, though in fact both were worn about the same and both lay equally covered with fresh leaves. He promises to keep the first road for another day, but he knows that “way leads on to way” and doubts whether he will ever come back. Ages later, he says, he will tell the story with a sigh: two roads divided in a wood, and he took the one less travelled by, and that has made all the difference. The two roads are a symbol of the choices of life, and the poem's message is that a small decision, made in a single moment, can shape a whole life, and that every choice also means the loss of the road not taken.

Points to Remember

• Poet: Robert Frost (1874–1963); published 1916; four stanzas of five lines, rhyme abaab.

• Setting: a yellow wood in autumn, where two roads diverge.

• Despite the title, the poem says both roads were "really about the same" and "equally lay in leaves".

• Key line: "I took the one less traveled by, / And that has made all the difference."

• Key words: diverged, undergrowth, wanted wear, trodden black, way leads on to way, hence, sigh.

• Symbolism: two roads = choices of life; leaves = a fresh decision; the sigh = mixed feelings (pride, nostalgia, regret).

• Summary vs precis vs paraphrase: summary = short version of the whole; precis = one-third, no opinion; paraphrase = word-by-word restatement in your own words.

• Book review parts: introduction, summary, analysis, opinion, conclusion.

• Sentence types: simple (one clause), compound (two joined by and/but/so), complex (main + subordinate clause).